

DIGITAL EDITION

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# The Indian Wedding Budget Playbook

**2026-27 Season**

The complete money system for the compressed 2026-27 season:  
budgets, venues, GST, jewellery, loans, insurance and paperwork

46 lakh weddings. Eleven muhurat dates. Rs. 6.5 lakh crore of spending.

This is how your family keeps its share of the season affordable.

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## 1. Read This First: The Season You Are Planning For

If you are reading this in September or October 2026, you are either planning a wedding in the November-December 2026 window, or you have your eye on the January-February 2027 season. Both are unusual, and both reward families who plan with the calendar in front of them.

The Hindu wedding calendar pauses for four months every year during Chaturmas. This year it ends on Dev Uthani Ekadashi, Friday 20 November 2026. The first vivah muhurat falls the very next day, Saturday 21 November. After that, the season runs for barely three weeks before Kharvas begins on 16 December and shuts the calendar again until Makar Sankranti on 14 January 2027.

Count the dates. Between 21 November and 12 December 2026 there are roughly eleven auspicious wedding dates, verified across leading panchang compilations: 21, 24, 25 and 26 November, then 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11 and 12 December. That is the entire winter window. Five of them are weekdays. When millions of families compete for the same handful of Saturdays in the same few weeks, every venue, caterer and photographer in the country is negotiating from strength. That is the single most important economic fact about the season you are shopping in.

The 2027 side of the season is different. After the season resumes on 15 January 2027, the year opens up: panchang compilations count around 96 auspicious wedding dates in 2027 against roughly 52 in 2026. January carries about nine to ten dates and February about thirteen. More dates mean less scarcity pricing, more vendor availability, and room to pick an off-peak day without offending anyone's pandit. If your family has flexibility, 2027 is where the savings are.

What this playbook does: it puts a defensible number on every big decision, from the per-plate catering contract to the marriage registration fee. Every rupee figure in here is sourced from either an official document or a named industry study published within the last two years, and the source is printed next to it. Where something varies by state or by vendor, it says so.

One more thing before the numbers. The Indian wedding economy is enormous, which is exactly why everyone selling to you is practised and you are (usually) a first-time buyer. The Confederation of All India Traders (CAIT) estimated the November-December 2025 season alone at Rs. 6.5 lakh crore across 46 lakh weddings, its study conducted across 75 cities. An average Indian family spends close to three times its annual income on a wedding, according to an analysis by Jefferies. You are making one of the largest financial decisions of your life against counterparties who do this every single weekend. A playbook is not paranoia; it is parity.

## 2. The Numbers: What an Indian Wedding Costs Today

Start with the two averages that get quoted most, because they measure different things. Across all income bands, an Indian family spends roughly Rs. 12 lakh per wedding, close to three times its annual income, per the Jefferies analysis of India's roughly \$130 billion wedding market. Among couples planning vendor-driven, multi-event weddings on the wedding platform WedMeGood, the 2025-26 average budget is far higher: Rs. 39.5 lakh, up 8% year on year, from its fifth annual survey of more than 2,000 couples and 500 wedding professionals. The truth for most families sits between the two, and depends almost entirely on two variables: your city and your guest list.

## What families spent, 2025-26 (WedMeGood Annual Wedding Report)

| Measure                                    | Average spend                     |
|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Overall average wedding budget             | Rs. 39.5 lakh (+8% YoY)           |
| Destination wedding                        | Rs. 58 lakh (2024: Rs. 51.1 lakh) |
| Jaipur (destination-led, highest in India) | Rs. 73 lakh                       |
| Delhi                                      | Rs. 38 lakh                       |
| Bengaluru                                  | Rs. 37 lakh                       |
| Hyderabad                                  | Rs. 37 lakh                       |
| Mumbai                                     | Rs. 35 lakh                       |

Source: WedMeGood 5th Annual Wedding Report, December 2025, surveying couples married April 2025 to March 2026.

City averages hide the wider spread. Market analyses put tier-2 city weddings at Rs. 15-25 lakh on average and tier-3 and rural weddings at Rs. 3-15 lakh, together accounting for the majority of India's weddings by volume. Wherever your wedding sits on that spread, the category shares below still hold; only the scale changes.

The CAIT numbers explain where all that money goes. Its 75-city study of the November-December 2025 season put jewellery first at 15% of all wedding expenditure, followed by apparel and sarees at 10% and catering at 10%. Event management took 5%, photography and videography 2%, floral decoration 4%, musical groups 3%, light and sound 3%, and travel and hospitality 3%. Electronics and electricals took 5%, dry fruits and sweets 5%, grocery and vegetables 5%, gift items 4%, and other goods and services covered the rest. Delhi alone accounted for 4.8 lakh weddings and Rs. 1.8 lakh crore of trade. The season was projected to add about Rs. 75,000 crore to government tax revenue and create over one crore temporary jobs.

Two more numbers from the same body of research shape this whole playbook. First, an average wedding runs on roughly 14 separate vendors. Second, only about 1-2% of budgets now go to digital content creation and social coverage, while online invitation platforms and AI-based planning tools are growing 20-25% a year, per CAIT. The market has professionalised; the savings go to families who negotiate like professionals.

## Where the money goes in a typical budget

### Typical share of budget by category (multi-event Indian wedding)

| Category                   | Share of budget | On Rs. 25 lakh  | On Rs. 50 lakh |
|----------------------------|-----------------|-----------------|----------------|
| Venue and catering         | 40-45%          | Rs. 10-11.25 L  | Rs. 20-22.5 L  |
| Decor and flowers          | 15-20%          | Rs. 3.75-5 L    | Rs. 7.5-10 L   |
| Attire and jewellery       | 10-15%          | Rs. 2.5-3.75 L  | Rs. 5-7.5 L    |
| Photography and video      | 8-10%           | Rs. 2-2.5 L     | Rs. 4-5 L      |
| Entertainment and music    | 5-8%            | Rs. 1.25-2 L    | Rs. 2.5-4 L    |
| Makeup and mehendi         | 3-5%            | Rs. 0.75-1.25 L | Rs. 1.5-2.5 L  |
| Invitations and stationery | 2-3%            | Rs. 0.5-0.75 L  | Rs. 1-1.5 L    |
| Contingency (keep this)    | 5-10%           | Rs. 1.25-2.5 L  | Rs. 2.5-5 L    |

Directional splits used by planners; derived from WedMeGood 2025-26 data and market analyses. Use them as a starting grid, not a rule.

Read the table twice, once down the column and once across. Down: venue and catering together swallow almost half of everything, which is why Chapter 6 is the longest in this book. Across: on a Rs. 50 lakh wedding, moving your guest list from 500 to 350 people is worth roughly Rs. 6-8 lakh in catering alone, more than most families will save from every other negotiation combined.

The per-guest lens is the most useful arithmetic in this book. At the national platform average of Rs. 39.5 lakh across roughly 350 guests, a wedding costs about Rs. 11,000 per guest. Destination weddings run at about Rs. 20,700 per guest, nearly double, on their smaller average list of 280 guests versus 420 for local celebrations (WedMeGood). Every time you add a name, you are not adding a chair; you are adding roughly Rs. 8,000-15,000 across food, decor, invitations, gifts and logistics.

The one-line budget formula: total budget = number of guests x per-guest spend + fixed costs (jewellery, clothes, honeymoon, registration). Set the guest count and the per-guest spend first; everything else is detail.

### 3. Set the Number Before the Pinterest Board

Families lose money in a predictable order: they book a venue, then discover what they have spent, then negotiate everything else from a position of weakness. Reverse it. The budget is not the output of planning; it is the input. Everything else in this book assumes you have a number.

#### The family money conversation

Have one meeting, early, with everyone who will contribute money or opinions: parents on both sides, and the couple. Four questions settle it. What savings are earmarked, on each side? What gifts and shagun can realistically be expected? Will anyone borrow, and how much repayment is comfortable? And what is the hard ceiling? Write the ceiling down. The number should include a 10% contingency that nobody touches until the last month, because every wedding runs over.

Keep three principles through that conversation. Both sides contribute openly or resentment surfaces later disguised as decoration arguments. The couple's financial life after the wedding matters more than the wedding itself; a Rs. 15.5 lakh loan (the average, per WedMeGood) repaid over five years at 13% costs about Rs. 5.4 lakh in interest, which is one entire decor budget spent on nothing you can photograph. And every rupee of gift money should be planned against the shortfall, not spent twice.

#### Three worked budgets

Here is what the same wedding looks like at three realistic Indian price points, using the category shares from Chapter 2. A 200-guest, single-venue, two-function wedding in a tier-2 city; a 350-guest, three-function metro wedding; and a 300-guest five-function celebration with a destination reception.

**Tier 1: The lean classic, Rs. 10 lakh, 200 guests, two functions**

| Category                                               | Allocation |
|--------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| Venue rental (community hall or hotel lawn)            | Rs. 1.5 L  |
| Catering, 200 guests x 2 functions x Rs. 900/plate avg | Rs. 3.6 L  |
| Decor and flowers (two functions, one theme reused)    | Rs. 1.2 L  |
| Clothes (couple plus close family, part rented)        | Rs. 1.5 L  |
| Jewellery (lightweight plus family gold reset)         | Rs. 1.0 L  |
| Photography (one team, two days)                       | Rs. 0.7 L  |
| Invitations, gifts, mehendi, music (DJ)                | Rs. 0.5 L  |
| Contingency 10%                                        | Rs. 1.0 L  |

Illustrative allocations by the author, anchored to the category shares in Chapter 2.

**Tier 2: The metro standard, Rs. 25 lakh, 350 guests, three functions**

| Category                                           | Allocation |
|----------------------------------------------------|------------|
| Venue (banquet per function)                       | Rs. 5.0 L  |
| Catering, 350 x 3 x Rs. 1,200 avg per plate        | Rs. 8.5 L  |
| Decor and flowers (three functions)                | Rs. 3.5 L  |
| Clothes (family of six, two outfits each)          | Rs. 2.5 L  |
| Jewellery (bridal set plus gifts)                  | Rs. 3.0 L  |
| Photography and video (candid team, three days)    | Rs. 2.0 L  |
| Invitations, gifts, makeup, mehendi, sangeet music | Rs. 1.5 L  |
| Contingency 10%                                    | Rs. 2.5 L  |

Illustrative allocations by the author.

**Tier 3: The grand celebration, Rs. 50 lakh, 300 guests, five functions, resort reception**

| Category                                              | Allocation |
|-------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| Venue, five functions incl. resort rooms block        | Rs. 11.0 L |
| Catering and beverages                                | Rs. 12.5 L |
| Decor and production (five functions)                 | Rs. 8.0 L  |
| Clothes (extended family, designer pieces)            | Rs. 5.0 L  |
| Jewellery                                             | Rs. 6.0 L  |
| Photography, video, drone, same-day edit              | Rs. 3.5 L  |
| Entertainment, anchor, choreographer, makeup, mehendi | Rs. 2.5 L  |
| Contingency 10%                                       | Rs. 5.0 L  |

Illustrative allocations by the author. Destination-style structure per CoTrav: 20-25% venues, 10-15% guest travel, 50-60% decor, food, planning.

Do not copy these tables; recalibrate them. The point of writing your own version is that arguments about a spreadsheet are cheaper than arguments about a floral arch on the morning of the sangeet. Once each line has a number and an owner, every vendor conversation in the rest of this book plugs into a slot that already exists.

### The rules that keep the number real

- One bank account for the wedding. All inflows (savings, gifts, loan disbursement) and all outflows through it. If money moves through six accounts, you have no budget, only a feeling.
- The contingency is not a target. If you end at plus 5%, the surplus goes to the honeymoon upgrade or the loan prepayment, not to a fourth entry gate.
- Cash payments above small amounts get a receipt or they did not happen. You will need those receipts for insurance claims and for returning or disputing anything.
- Track actuals against budget weekly during the final three months. A spreadsheet with a variance column beats any wedding planning app, because it is yours.

Rule of thumb for the ceiling: total wedding spending, including jewellery, should stay under what the family can pay without borrowing more than what the couple can repay from their own income within three years. Everything beyond that is borrowed joy.

## 4. The Guest List: Where Every Budget Is Actually Won

Every rupee in this book traces back to a single number: how many people are coming. Guest count drives catering, venue size, decor scale, invitations, gifts, accommodation and transport, comfortably more than half of a typical total spend. It is also the number families negotiate last and emotionally. Flip that: fix the count early, and most of the budget fixes itself.

The platform averages frame the opportunity. Local celebrations run about 420 guests on average; destination weddings about 280, and they cost less in total despite a far higher per-guest spend. Shrinking the list is the one lever that cuts every variable cost in the same stroke.

### What 100 extra guests actually cost (catering alone, Rs. 1,200 per plate, three functions)

| Guest count | Catering bill | Vs. a 200-guest wedding |
|-------------|---------------|-------------------------|
| 200         | Rs. 7.2 lakh  | -                       |
| 300         | Rs. 10.8 lakh | + Rs. 3.6 lakh          |
| 400         | Rs. 14.4 lakh | + Rs. 7.2 lakh          |
| 500         | Rs. 18.0 lakh | + Rs. 10.8 lakh         |

Illustrative arithmetic at one mid-market per-plate rate; add decor scale, invitations, gifts and logistics on top.

Most families settle the list in four unspoken tiers. Tier one: immediate family and closest friends, non-negotiable. Tier two: extended family and must-invites, fixed by tradition and by who came to your cousin's wedding. Tier three: your parents' social and professional circles, where the real negotiation lives. Tier four: friends, colleagues and plus-ones, entirely yours to cut. Agree a per-side quota in the Chapter 3 money meeting, in writing, before any list is drafted.



Then work the declines, not the invitations. Families typically see 10-20% of invited guests decline a city function, and more when travel is involved; the caterer's minimum guarantee should be set on the realistic eating count, with final numbers confirmed about 72 hours out. Release invitations in waves: the first list goes out on schedule, and a small second list fills the real capacity as regrets arrive, which is how you keep both sets of parents happy without paying for empty chairs.

Track the answers digitally. CAIT's 2025 study found online invitation platforms and AI-based planning tools growing 20-25% a year in wedding-related sales, and a wedding website with RSVP costs a fraction of one printed invitation batch. Three weeks of real counts before the final caterer confirmation is worth more than any discount you will negotiate all season.

The sentence that saves more money than any negotiation in this book: 'We would love to invite everyone, but we are keeping it small.' Rehearse it, agree who says it, and let it be your family's shared position rather than one person's refusal.

## 5. The Muhurat Calendar Decides Your Bill

In most years the calendar spreads demand across months. In 2026-27 it does not, and the calendar is therefore a financial document. The verified shape of the season: Chaturmas ends on Dev Uthani Ekadashi, Friday 20 November 2026. The first muhurat of the season is Saturday 21 November (also Tulsi Vivah, the ritual opening of the wedding year). November then offers 21, 24, 25 and 26. December offers 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11 and 12 before Kharman begins on 16 December and the calendar closes. It reopens after Makar Sankranti, 14 January 2027, with roughly nine to ten dates in January and about thirteen in February.

### The 2026-27 muhurat map (North Indian panchang convention)

| Window                 | Dates                              | What it means for money                                                                       |
|------------------------|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>21-26 Nov 2026</b>  | Sat 21, Tue 24, Wed 25, Thu 26     | Highest demand window of the season. Peak venue premiums; book or pay up.                     |
| <b>2-6 Dec 2026</b>    | Wed 2, Thu 3, Fri 4, Sat 5, Sun 6  | A five-day run ending on a Sunday. The 5th is the second-most-expensive Saturday of the year. |
| <b>11-12 Dec 2026</b>  | Fri 11, Sat 12                     | Last dates of 2026. Vendors with open calendars deal, because the alternative is nothing.     |
| <b>16 Dec - 14 Jan</b> | Kharman / Dhanurmasa               | No dates. Prime negotiation month for the January season.                                     |
| <b>15-31 Jan 2027</b>  | About 9-10 dates                   | Season resumes. Demand moderate, weather kind, prices softer than November.                   |
| <b>Feb 2027</b>        | About 13 dates                     | Widest choice of the season. The negotiating sweet spot.                                      |
| <b>2027 overall</b>    | About 96 dates vs about 52 in 2026 | Bumper year. Off-peak dates are genuinely available.                                          |

Compiled from Drik Panchang-based compilations and leading panchang services, September 2026. Regional panchangs differ by a day on some dates; always confirm the final date and lagna with your family pandit.

Three practical consequences. First, if you are marrying in the November window and have not booked a venue as of late September, treat that as the week's most urgent task; in a compressed season, good venues for 21 November and 5 December go first. Second, a weekday date (Tuesday 24 November, Wednesday 2 December) routinely prices 10-20% lower than the adjacent Saturday for the same hall,

caterer and photographer, and vendors often throw in extras to fill the day. Third, if you can move to January or February 2027, you gain negotiating power everywhere: more dates, more availability, and vendors looking at a long season rather than a sold-out fortnight.

The Kharma's bonus: between 16 December and 14 January, vendors have no weddings to deliver. That is the single best month of the year to sit across a table and negotiate a February package, because everyone's calendar is empty and their fixed costs are running.

## 6. Venue and Catering: The 45% You Control Most

Venue and catering are 40-45% of a typical budget and close to 100% of your risk. They are booked first, paid earliest, and hardest to unwind. This chapter is long because the money is here.

### Booking windows in a compressed season

Standard advice says book a venue 9-12 months out. The 2026-27 season has broken that rule. With barely eleven dates between 21 November and 12 December, families have been booking earlier and earlier, and the popular venues for the November Saturdays were committed well before this playbook was written. Your realistic plays now: weekday dates, the 11-12 December window where some vendors still have gaps, or the roomier January-February 2027 calendar. Get quotes from at least five venues before you sign anything, and get each quote in writing on the same guest count so they are comparable.

### How venue quotes are actually built

- Rental fee for the hall or lawn, charged per function or per day, sometimes scaled to declared guest count.
- Catering on a per-plate basis, which covers food, service staff and cleanup, and is quoted with or without GST depending on the vendor's candour.
- A minimum guarantee (MG): the number of plates you commit to pay for even if fewer guests eat. Vendors protect themselves with it; you protect yourself by setting it from a realistic count, not the invitation list.
- Add-ons quoted separately: decor in-house or compulsory empanelled decorators, DJ and sound, valet, generator, room blocks, service charges and taxes.

The per-plate number is where most budgets quietly die. When you negotiate, negotiate the total function cost, not the headline per-plate rate. A caterer who drops from Rs. 1,500 to Rs. 1,350 per plate and then charges 12% service charge on food plus separate staffing for 40 servers has taken back more than the discount gave you.

### The GST structure, in plain words

Wedding services attract GST at 5% or 18% depending on how the supply is structured, and the difference is large enough to change your venue choice. The essential logic, as laid out in Economic Times Wealth analyses and GST practitioner guidance: catering as a pure food service generally attracts 5% without input tax credit; hotel and banquet services, decor, photography, music and artist hire generally attract 18%. A hotel whose declared room tariff exceeds Rs. 7,500 per night attracts the higher rate on its banquet services too, which is why the same wedding costs visibly more GST at a five-star property than at a club or a standalone banquet hall.

The trap is bundling. If one contract covers venue, catering, decor and photography for a single price, tax authorities can treat it as a mixed supply and levy the highest rate, 18%, on the whole amount. Split it, and the catering part can sit at the lower rate while decor and photography attract 18% only on their own value. The ET Wealth worked example: a venue-catering package of Rs. 10 lakh plus Rs. 4 lakh of decor and photography bundled into one contract could attract 18% on all Rs. 14 lakh, about Rs. 2.52 lakh of tax. Segregated into separate contracts and bills, the tax fell to roughly Rs. 1.22 lakh, a saving of about Rs. 1.3 lakh, more than a full photography budget. Note that GST rate structures were revised in the September 2025 GST reform; treat these as the structural logic, and confirm the final applicable rate on the written quote against the vendor's GSTIN.

- Ask every venue for the quote split into: rental, catering, decor, other services; each with its own GST line and rate.
- Compare venues on total cost for your exact guest count and function list, including taxes, not on the per-plate headline.
- If a venue insists on one price, ask what the mixed-supply GST treatment will be, in writing, before you sign.
- Collect proper tax invoices. Without them you cannot dispute, claim insurance, or prove what you paid.

### Questions that earn their keep before you sign

- What exactly is included in the rental: hours, setup and teardown time, power backup, parking, changing rooms, bridal suite?
- Is the decorator in-house or empanelled, and can you bring your own at a buyout fee? (The buyout is often cheaper than the markup.)
- What is the minimum guarantee, and can unused plates convert to something with value, like extra breakfasts or vendor meals?
- What is the cancellation and date-change policy, and what exactly happens to the advance if a date moves within the same season?
- Which taxes apply to which lines, and is the quoted figure inclusive or exclusive of GST?
- Is there a service charge on food, and is it a percentage of the food bill or a flat staffing fee?
- What is the overtime rate if the baraat runs two hours late?

### Negotiating like the market does

Three levers work in India's wedding market. Dates: weekday and January-February dates give you room; 21 November and 5 December do not. Volume: bundling two or three functions at one venue genuinely earns discounts, if you keep the contracts line-separated for GST purposes. Flexibility on payment terms: a vendor who gets 70% upfront and 30% on the day will often shave the total versus one who collects on delivery. Always keep a retention: 10-20% payable after the last function clears. It is the only quality-control mechanism you will actually have.

### Three conversations, annotated

You are not being difficult; you are being clear. Vendors prefer a clear brief to a hesitant one, and clarity about budget, dates and alternatives is what moves quotes. Adapt the wording to your own voice, but keep the three anchors in each conversation: the total you are working with, the alternatives you are comparing, and the date.

- At the venue: 'Our budget for the venue across all functions is X. We are comparing five properties this week for the 5th of December. What can you put together within that, rental, catering and taxes included?' You have anchored the total, named the competition and named the date, the three facts that change a quote.
- With the caterer: 'Our realistic count is 300 and we expect 10-15% declines. Set the minimum guarantee at 260 and we will confirm final numbers 72 hours out. Quote all-in per plate, with service charge, staffing and GST on separate lines.'
- With the decorator: 'One theme carried across all three functions, structures reused wherever possible. Give me continuity pricing, and quote flowers in season and sourced locally.' Reuse and local sourcing are the two biggest decor levers.

After each conversation, get the revised number in writing the same day. Verbal discounts evaporate between the visit and the contract, and every vendor quotes differently to a family that sounds decided than to one still comparing.

The advance is a negotiation, too. Typical Indian market practice runs 25-40% at booking, a similar tranche mid-way, and the balance on or after the day. Anything above 50% before the wedding week should be refused unless there is a written refund and cancellation clause you have actually read.

## 7. Jewellery at Record Gold Prices

No line item has moved like jewellery. Gold began 2025 at Rs. 79,390 per 10 grams and finished the year above Rs. 1.38 lakh, a rise of about 74% during 2025, per rates reported by the All India Gem and Jewellery Domestic Council. As of late September 2026, benchmark 24-carat gold stands near Rs. 1.49 lakh per 10 grams (Rs. 1,48,800 on 29 September 2026, per Business Today), with major retail chains quoting 22-carat between roughly Rs. 13,640 and Rs. 14,040 per gram. A bridal set that weighed the same as your cousin's 2023 set now costs about double.

CAIT's sector study put jewellery at 15% of all wedding expenditure, the single largest slice, ahead of catering. The market's response has been a quiet revolution in how families buy: the Gem and Jewellery Council reports that gold recycling, which was 10-15% of wedding jewellery before 2023, rose another 20-25% in FY25. Families are resetting inherited gold instead of buying new, and it is working.

### Six ways families are cutting the jewellery bill

- 1 Reset, don't buy. Old family gold re-polished, re-plated and re-set into a contemporary bridal set saves the entire metal cost; you pay only making charges. At current prices, the metal is 80-85% of the bill.
- 2 Buy by weight, not by look. Decide the gram budget before entering the store, and treat polki, kundan and antique finishes as design choices within it, not reasons to exceed it.
- 3 Rent the drama, buy the classic. One heirloom-quality solid set you keep, plus rented statement pieces for the sangeet and reception, is the pattern planners recommend most. Rental couture jewellery runs a fraction of making charges on pieces worn once.
- 4 Split the functions, not the set. Bridal wear changes per function anyway; a lighter set for the mehendi and a rented statement piece for the reception often photograph identically.

- 5 Time the purchase. Gold moves daily; jewellery bought on the wedding week's rate is a lottery. If your date is in 2027, average your purchases across two or three dips rather than buying in one emotional afternoon.
- 6 Hallmark and invoice, always. BIS hallmarking is mandatory for gold sales, and the invoice with weight, purity and making charge per gram is your protection on resale, exchange and insurance.

On making charges: they are quoted as a percentage of gold value or a flat per-gram rate, they vary widely between brands, and they are negotiable at almost every counter during wedding season. The National Consumer Helpline receives wedding-season complaints about making-charge disputes every year; the fix is one line on the invoice stating making charges per gram.

Insurance note for the jewellery itself: most home content policies cap jewellery cover, and wedding-day cover must often be declared separately. If you are buying wedding insurance (Chapter 11), declare the jewellery you will be wearing and transporting; insurers cover valuables at the venue under material damage sections, subject to limits stated in the policy schedule.

## 8. Clothes, Beauty and the Looks Budget

Apparel is 10-15% of a typical budget, about Rs. 4-6 lakh per wedding on clothing alone at current averages, per industry data cited in 2026 wedding fashion reporting. It is also the category with the widest gap between what is spent and what is worn more than once. The 2025-26 season's trends, per WedMeGood and designer commentary reported through the year, run towards personalisation: pastels over traditional reds for about 40% of brides, regional weaves over heavily embroidered couture, and multi-functional trousseaus designed to be re-worn.

### Where the looks budget goes further

- Rent the single-wear pieces. Sherwanis, lehengas for the sangeet and heavily worked outfits for family members are available on rental platforms in every metro at 10-25% of retail. Nobody at the reception can tell, and the photos are identical.
- Buy the re-wearables. The couple's outfits with future life (sarees, suits, kurtas) deserve the budget; the outfit worn for four hours does not.
- One designer piece, rest off-the-rack. The bridal lehenga is the one garment where most families say the spend is worth it; everything else scales down without visible loss.
- Book makeup and mehendi early but fixed-price. Top artists sell season packages for multiple functions; the compressed 2026 calendar means the good ones for 21 November and 5 December are booked months ahead.
- Shop the wedding season sales in the festive window. Retail jewellery and clothing discounting in the October festive period is real; November onwards it disappears.

One caution on gold-saving and jewellery instalment schemes run by retail chains: they are commercial products, not savings instruments, and their terms vary widely. If you use one, read the making-charge and forfeiture clauses before the first instalment, and treat any promised discount against making charges as the actual benefit, because the gold price risk stays with you either way.

## 9. Photography, Decor and the 14-Vendor Reality

An average Indian wedding runs on about 14 vendors, from the caterer and photographer down to the mehendi artist, the DJ and the generator supplier. Each one is a contract, an advance and a delivery date. The families who lose money in this layer do so not through bad prices but through bad paper: verbal confirmations, advances paid over UPI with no message trail, and deliverables nobody wrote down.

## Photography: what changed in 2025

The market moved towards social-first content. Industry data for 2025, reported by luxury photography studios, put the average spend per assignment about 6.8% below 2024 levels (though still about 22% above 2023), with couples paying for fast, Instagram-ready edits over exhaustive albums, and documentary-style candids over posed coverage. The practical takeaway: you can negotiate. Ask each photographer for a package shaped around what you will actually consume, two-day candid coverage with a set number of edited photos, a same-evening reel for the reception, and a full album delivered on a stated date.

### The vendor contract checklist (apply to every one of the 14)

| Clause                                | What it must say                                                                                           |
|---------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Scope</b>                          | Exactly what is delivered: hours, functions covered, team size, equipment, deliverables and their formats. |
| <b>Dates and venue</b>                | Every function date, venue address and setup time, not just the wedding day.                               |
| <b>Price and taxes</b>                | Total price, advance amount and date, balance schedule, GST rate and whether inclusive.                    |
| <b>Deliverables timeline</b>          | Number of edited photos, teaser and reel dates, album delivery date, raw footage policy.                   |
| <b>Substitution</b>                   | What happens if the lead photographer or main caterer falls ill; the named backup.                         |
| <b>Cancellation and force majeure</b> | Refund of advance if the date changes or a listed peril (per insurance) cancels the event.                 |
| <b>Defaults</b>                       | What you get compensated if delivery is late or short, and the dispute forum.                              |

Model clauses assembled from standard Indian event-contract practice and insurer policy wordings. Get each signed, with the vendor's GSTIN and PAN.

## Decor: the most negotiable big line

Decor is 15-20% of the budget and the least standardised: the same flowers, drapes and lights cost wildly different amounts depending on the planner, the city and the season. The single most effective ask is design continuity: one theme and one colour story carried across mehendi, haldi and sangeet, with structures reused between venues. Planners quote each function separately when left alone; continuity planning routinely cuts 15-20% off the decor total because fabric, staging and lighting get reused rather than rebuilt. Second ask: local and seasonal flowers. Imported and off-season blooms carry the heaviest markup; CAIT's Vocal for Local campaign has pushed Indian-grown decor into the mainstream, and the price gap is real.

## Running the advance ledger

Keep one table, updated weekly, with every vendor, the total agreed, every payment made, its date, its mode and the balance. Two reasons. It is your single source of truth in the final month when 14 vendors are all calling for payments, and it is the document your insurer or a court will ask for if anything goes wrong. The final week of an Indian wedding is run from this table; families without one discover double payments, forgotten balances and missing receipts only after the last function.



## 10. Destination Weddings Without the Rs. 58 Lakh Bill

One in four Indian weddings is now a destination wedding, and more than 60% of weddings with budgets over Rs. 1 crore are destination celebrations, per WedMeGood's 2025-26 survey. The average destination wedding on the platform costs Rs. 58 lakh, up from Rs. 51.1 lakh the previous year. Yet nearly 90% of destination weddings happen within India: the trend is not Bali, it is Rishikesh. The most-booked domestic destinations, per WedMeGood: Dehradun, Mussoorie, Rishikesh, Shimla, Jim Corbett, Udaipur, Jaipur, Jaisalmer, Jodhpur and Goa. Bali, Vietnam, Thailand and Malaysia lead only for those going abroad.

The economics are distinctive. Destination weddings run about 280 guests against 420 for local celebrations, and cost roughly Rs. 20,700 per guest versus Rs. 11,000, per the same survey. Five-star destination weddings today typically carry budgets above Rs. 3 crore, with about 20-25% on premium venues, 10-15% on guest and family travel, around 10% on artistes and crew logistics, and the remaining 50-60% on decor, food and planning, per B2B travel concierge CoTrav's account of roughly 60 luxury destination weddings in 2025.

### Why families do it anyway

Because the per-guest experience is the product. A 280-guest wedding in Rishikesh with two nights of resort stay, curated meals and one venue for everything can cost less per day-of-joy than a 500-guest Delhi farmhouse marathon of commutes and near-identical banquet food. The comparison is not destination versus home at equal guest counts; it is a smaller, contained celebration versus a larger, scattered one.

### How to do it without the average bill

- Cut the guest list before anything else. The 420-to-280 drop is the entire economic case; going below 150 changes the market you are shopping in (private estates and boutique resorts rather than wedding-gear five-stars).
- Pick your dates from the 2027 calendar. February 2027 has about thirteen dates; a Wednesday or Thursday destination date shifts resort pricing meaningfully versus a November Saturday.
- Buy rooms as a block, and negotiate the block. Resorts discount committed room-nights; the leverage is agreeing the room count early and in writing.
- One venue, all functions. Travel between venues is where destination budgets quietly double: transport, decor re-installation and guest shuttles.
- Local decor and local flowers. Rajasthan and Uttarakhand have deep local supply chains; importing a Delhi decorator adds logistics and hotel loading.
- All-inclusive packages can work for the 100-150 guest range, but audit them line by line: the room block, the meal count and the decor allowance are where packages under-deliver.

Destination plus insurance: destination weddings are covered by Indian wedding insurance, including at international locations, subject to location-specific terms and costs. If guests are flying in, event cancellation and money-in-transit covers earn their premium. See Chapter 11.

## 11. Paying For It: Savings, Loans and Wedding Insurance

How Indian families actually fund weddings, per WedMeGood's 2025-26 survey: 78.65% from personal savings, 15.2% through loans (8.85% from banks, 6.25% from friends and family), and 6.25% by liquidating assets. The average wedding loan is Rs. 15.5 lakh, typically applied to venues, jewellery, decor and catering. Savings-first remains the national pattern, and it is the right one.

## What loans actually cost in 2026

A marriage loan is a standard unsecured personal loan wearing a different label. Banks price it on your credit score and income, and there is no special wedding subsidy. Advertised starting rates from major lenders cluster just under 10%, with the realistic band for most salaried borrowers running to about 15-24% depending on profile, and digital lenders higher still.

### Indicative marriage loan rates, major lenders (early 2026)

| Lender         | Advertised rate (p.a.) | Max amount     | Max tenure |
|----------------|------------------------|----------------|------------|
| HDFC Bank      | 9.99% - 24%            | Rs. 40-50 lakh | 6 years    |
| Axis Bank      | From 9.99%             | Rs. 40 lakh    | 6 years    |
| ICICI Bank     | From 10.45%            | Rs. 50 lakh    | 6 years    |
| SBI            | 10.05% - 15.05%        | Rs. 35 lakh    | 7 years    |
| PNB            | From 10.60%            | Rs. 20 lakh    | 6 years    |
| Kotak Mahindra | From 10.99%            | Rs. 35 lakh    | 6 years    |

Rates as published by lenders and aggregators (HDFC Bank product page updated October 2025; BankBazaar and MyMudra 2026 comparisons). Starting rates are for strong credit profiles (CIBIL 750+, salaried); processing fees run to about 2-3% plus GST. Verify current rates with the lender before deciding.

Run the EMI arithmetic before the bank does it for you. Rs. 15 lakh at 13% over five years is about Rs. 34,000 a month and over Rs. 5.4 lakh in total interest. Rs. 10 lakh at 13% over five years is about Rs. 22,750 a month and Rs. 3.65 lakh of interest. A useful discipline: keep total EMIs (all loans, including this one) under roughly 40% of the household's net monthly income, and prefer a tenure you can prepay once shagun and gift money arrives. Confirm prepayment and foreclosure charges in writing before signing, not after.

### What a five-year wedding loan really costs (EMI per month)

| Loan amount | At 11% p.a. | At 13% p.a. | At 15% p.a. |
|-------------|-------------|-------------|-------------|
| Rs. 5 lakh  | Rs. 10,871  | Rs. 11,377  | Rs. 11,895  |
| Rs. 10 lakh | Rs. 21,742  | Rs. 22,753  | Rs. 23,790  |
| Rs. 15 lakh | Rs. 32,614  | Rs. 34,130  | Rs. 35,685  |

Standard reducing-balance EMI over 60 months. Total interest over five years on a Rs. 15 lakh loan: about Rs. 4.57 lakh at 11%, Rs. 5.48 lakh at 13% and Rs. 6.41 lakh at 15%. A three-year tenure cuts interest sharply but raises the monthly EMI.

- Check CIBIL months before you need money. Above 750 unlocks the sub-11% band; below 700 pushes you to 16%+ or to NBFCs.
- Compare your own bank's pre-approved offer against two others; pre-approved is convenient, not necessarily cheapest.
- Cheaper secured options first: a gold loan (family gold stays pledged, rates several points lower, near-instant approval, but you lose the gold if you default and short tenures compress repayment) or a loan against fixed deposits.



- Never fund a wedding on credit card instalments or app-based instant credit at 20%+; that is the most expensive money in the system.

### Wedding insurance: what it is and whether you need it

Indian insurers sell wedding cover as customised event insurance. ICICI Lombard, Future Generali (Vivah Suraksha), Bajaj Allianz, Oriental Insurance and National Insurance have all offered it. Premiums are typically 0.2-2% of the sum insured depending on covers chosen, per Economic Times reporting; industry executives quoted indicative pricing from about Rs. 1,500 for a basic Rs. 5 lakh cover to Rs. 25,000-30,000 for an elaborate Rs. 50 lakh cover, and as low as about Rs. 2,500 plus GST for a Rs. 20 lakh cancellation-only cover at one insurer. The policy runs for the event duration, from a single day to about 15 days for multi-day celebrations.

What it covers, per insurer policy wordings: event cancellation or postponement due to listed perils (unseasonal rain as declared by the weather office, fire, flood or cyclone damaging the venue, riots or curfew within 25 km of the venue, death or accident leading to 72-hour-plus hospitalisation of the bride, groom or blood relatives, transport stranding); material damage to wedding property including decor, equipment and gifted jewellery within stated limits; public liability for third-party injury at the venue; personal accident cover; and money-in-transit for cash being carried to vendors.

What it does not cover, and this list matters more: a change of mind or wedding jitters; disputes between the couple or families; seasonal or expected rains; bandhs and strikes unless curfew is declared; vendor failure (some wordings exclude it, others offer vendor no-show as an add-on); pre-existing circumstances; financial inability to pay; and pregnancy-related cancellations. Read the exclusions page twice before the schedule page once.

Buy or skip? The honest test: if your budget exceeds roughly Rs. 50 lakh, the premium (under Rs. 30,000 for the largest covers) is small against the cancellation exposure of advances already paid, and insurers report most uptake happens at this budget level. Below that, a basic cancellation-only cover for the advance amounts you cannot afford to lose is still reasonable; a full cover for a Rs. 8 lakh wedding rarely earns its premium.

## 12. When Things Go Wrong: Claims, Disputes and Complaints

Even well-run weddings hit problems: a vendor delivers short, decor collapses in unseasonal wind, cash goes missing, or a listed peril postpones the date itself. The families who recover quickly are the ones with paper: contracts, invoices, payment records and photographs. Everything in this chapter assumes you kept them.

### An insurance claim, step by step

- Notify the insurer the same day, by phone and then in writing. Delay in intimation is the single most common reason claims are questioned.
- Assemble the file: claim form, policy schedule, invoices and receipts for every advance, photographs of the damage or loss, the FIR copy in case of theft, hospitalisation records for medical claims, and the vendor contract.

- Expect a surveyor for material damage: the insurer's assessor inspects and values the loss before any payout. Cooperate, and keep copies of everything you hand over.
- Payout follows assessment of a genuine claim. If you are dissatisfied, escalate to the insurer's grievance officer first, then to the IRDAI's Bima Bharosa grievance portal.

### A vendor dispute, step by step

- Re-read the contract before you make the call, and quote it, not your memory of it.
- Write once, calmly: state the gap between what was contracted and what was delivered, with dates, amounts and the remedy you want by a fixed date.
- Keep every payment record and written confirmation; the advance ledger from Chapter 9 is your evidence file.
- Weigh the fight. For small shortfalls, a written complaint and a withheld retention may be the whole story; for larger ones, the consumer route is straightforward.

The consumer route runs through the National Consumer Helpline (1915) for pre-litigation advice and mediation, and through the government's e-daakhil portal for filing a complaint with the consumer commission of the right level for your claim. Keep it factual: dates, amounts, documents, and the relief sought. If you paid a large vendor bill by credit card for services not delivered, your issuing bank's dispute window is also worth knowing; instant payment methods leave no such window, which is one more reason large balances are safer on instruments that leave a trail.

## 13. The Paperwork: Marriage Registration

The wedding is not legally complete until it is registered, and unregistered marriages cause real pain later: passports, visas, name changes, bank accounts and insurance all ask for the certificate. The process is cheap (fees run in the hundreds of rupees) and mostly online now, but it has timing rules that interact with your muhurat calendar, so plan it alongside the venue, not after.

### Which Act applies

Two laws govern registration. The Hindu Marriage Act, 1955 applies when both parties are Hindus, Buddhists, Jains or Sikhs, and is the quicker route: no waiting period, certificate typically issued within 7-15 working days of the appointment in most states. The Special Marriage Act, 1954 applies to inter-faith and civil marriages, and carries a mandatory 30-day public notice at the Marriage Officer's office after the notice of intended marriage is filed, with the notice valid for three months. If you are marrying under the Special Marriage Act in the winter 2026 window, the notice math works backwards: file by mid-October for a late-November solemnisation.

**Registration fees and timelines (indicative, state portals)**

| Item                                               | Fee              | Timeline                         |
|----------------------------------------------------|------------------|----------------------------------|
| Delhi, Hindu Marriage Act registration             | Rs. 100          | Certificate in about 14 days     |
| Delhi, Special Marriage Act application            | Rs. 150          | 30-day notice, then registration |
| Maharashtra, SMA application                       | Rs. 100          | Online notice, 30-day period     |
| Maharashtra, SMA solemnisation at registrar office | Rs. 150          | Within 3 months of notice        |
| Maharashtra, SMA solemnisation at another venue    | Rs. 1,000        | By appointment                   |
| Maharashtra, marriage certificate                  | Rs. 25           | 1 hour to 15 days by case        |
| Delhi Tatkal (already-married couples)             | Rs. 2,500 + fees | 1-3 working days                 |

From the Delhi Revenue Department and Maharashtra IGR official checklists. Fees and timelines vary by state; verify on your state's e-district portal.

**Documents to keep ready**

- Aadhaar and PAN for both parties; identity proof for three witnesses.
- Age proof: birth certificate, Class 10 certificate or passport (some Delhi zones do not accept Aadhaar as age proof).
- Address proof: voter ID, ration card, passport or utility bill.
- Marriage proof: invitation card, a certificate from the priest or venue, ceremonial and joint photographs.
- Affidavits of marital status; divorce decree or former spouse's death certificate where applicable.

Most states accept online applications through e-district portals with fee payment by UPI or net banking, but both partners and witnesses must appear in person before the registrar with originals. Book the appointment the day the portal opens slots for your wedding week; end-of-season weeks fill up. And keep certified copies: you will need them more often than you expect, for the passport office first.

**14. The Last 30 Days and the Wedding Week**

The final month is not when money is saved; it is when money is protected. Every rupee of negotiation happened earlier. What remains is confirmation, coordination and cash management across about 14 vendors, and it runs on two documents: the advance ledger from Chapter 9 and the day schedule.

- Week minus four: written confirmation to every vendor with date, venue, setup time and contact person. A two-line reply from each, even on WhatsApp, beats a phone call you cannot produce later.
- Week minus three: final guest count, then lock the caterer's minimum guarantee. Reconfirm room blocks and transport for destination weddings.
- Week minus two: the money plan. Cash in labelled envelopes by vendor and function (the envelope system survives every technology); card limits raised for the day; the insurance policy document printed and shared with two family members.
- Week minus one: site visit with the venue, decorator and photographer together. One walk-through catches more conflicts than a hundred phone calls.

- **Wedding week:** a single family WhatsApp group for vendors; one named person per function empowered to sign off deliveries; the balance-payment schedule executed from the ledger, never from memory.
- **The day after:** collect every pending item in writing, including the photographer's delivery dates and the venue's deposit return. Start the insurance claim window if anything went wrong; most policies require prompt intimation.

## The run sheet for the week itself

The last month's ledger becomes a run sheet: one printed page, six blocks, each with a named owner. Print it, put it in the hands of every owner, and pin one copy at the venue office. On the day, nobody coordinates anything that is not on the sheet.

### The wedding-week run sheet

| Block                      | What it covers                                                   | Owner                               |
|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| <b>Master schedule</b>     | Every function, date, time, venue, vendor arrival and setup slot | One coordinator                     |
| <b>Vendor ledger</b>       | Payments due, advances paid, balances, receipts on hand          | One finance owner                   |
| <b>Guest logistics</b>     | Pickups, room allocation, transport, welcome kits                | One travel owner                    |
| <b>Ceremony logistics</b>  | Pandit, items, timing with the lagna, seating                    | A family elder with the coordinator |
| <b>Gifts and envelopes</b> | Incoming shagun recorded and stored, outgoing gifts and favours  | Two people, always together         |
| <b>Emergencies</b>         | First aid, contacts, venue manager, doctor on call               | One named person                    |

Post-wedding money moves, in order: start the loan EMI or its prepayment plan with gift money before it dissolves; complete the registration if not already done; move remaining envelope cash back to the bank same-week; and update nominees on insurance and bank accounts once the certificate is in hand.

## 15. The Honeymoon: The Last Line of the Budget

The honeymoon is the only line of the wedding budget the couple controls alone: no committees, no guest-list diplomacy, no expectations to manage. It deserves the same discipline as the rest. Give it a number in the Chapter 3 money meeting, keep it separate from the wedding contingency, and spend it on the trip you actually want, not the one photographs best.

Timing is the main lever. Flying out the morning after a peak-season wedding means paying peak fares and peak hotel rates for two. A gap of even ten days, or a shoulder-season departure, routinely moves both meaningfully, and the weeks after the winter season are the lean travel window across most of India. If you are marrying in the 21 November to 12 December window, your best-value travel dates are mid-January to March.

Choose the experience before the destination: mountains, beach, city, food or heritage, then match a place to it. Domestic options deliver all five at a fraction of international cost, with no visa at all; if you are set on going abroad, Southeast Asia's e-visa and visa-on-arrival options keep planning simple, but flights and season will matter more to the bill than the visa.

- Book flights early for peak dates, and hold flexible-cancellation fares; wedding dates move, and non-refundable tickets are the most common honeymoon loss.
- Buy travel insurance for international trips, and check that it covers the jewellery you are carrying if you wear any.
- Agree the spending-money rules before the trip: a shared card, a daily budget, and what counts as a splurge.
- Resist upgrading the trip with money saved elsewhere in the wedding budget; the surplus belongs to the couple's first year, not the first week.

## 16. The 25 Biggest Money Traps, Ranked

Collected from consumer complaint patterns, insurer exclusion lists and the standard vendor playbook. They are ranked roughly by how often they cost Indian families real money.

- 1 Paying an advance with no written contract. The single most common way families lose money. If it is not in writing, the refund conversation does not exist.
- 2 One bundled contract for venue, catering, decor and photography. Can convert the entire amount to 18% GST as a mixed supply instead of the split rates. Ask for line-item contracts and bills.
- 3 Booking a peak Saturday in the compressed 2026 window without comparing five venues. Scarcity is priced in; you pay it unless you compare.
- 4 Catering minimum guarantees set from the invitation list instead of the realistic attendance. You pay for empty plates; 15-20% of invitees decline a destination wedding, more for weekday city functions.
- 5 Jewellery bought on emotion in one afternoon at peak season rates, with making charges accepted as quoted. Both are negotiable; ask for making charges per gram on the invoice.
- 6 The five-star venue whose room tariff exceeds Rs. 7,500, silently lifting banquet GST to the higher rate versus the club down the road.
- 7 Venue-decorator exclusivity markup. Compulsory in-house decorators carry built-in margin; a buyout fee is often cheaper.
- 8 Photographer packages bought per day when the deliverable you want is per function. Pay for the two functions that matter, not three days of presence.
- 9 Advances above 50% before the wedding week, with no refund clause.
- 10 Destination weddings planned without a room-block contract; guests book separately, the resort loses the guarantee, and rates reset upward.
- 11 Cash payments without GST invoices. No invoice means no dispute rights, no insurance evidence, and no refund trail.
- 12 The 'wedding loan' approved in minutes at 20%+ because it was pre-approved and convenient. Compare three lenders first; the label carries no discount.
- 13 Service charges discovered late: 8-12% on catering and venue bills, plus staffing, plus power, plus valet. Demand the all-in quote.
- 14 Last-minute vendor substitution (a junior photographer, a smaller decor team) because nobody named the backup in the contract.

- 15 Insurance bought for the sum insured of the whole wedding instead of for the advances you cannot recover; over-insurance pays premium for nothing.
- 16 Seasonal rain assumed covered. Insurers pay only for unseasonal rain as declared by the weather authority; expected seasonal rain is excluded.
- 17 Change-of-mind and family-dispute exclusions ignored. No Indian insurer pays for a wedding called off by the families.
- 18 Overtime and generator charges on the night. Baraats run late; negotiate the overtime rate at booking when it costs a fraction.
- 19 The open bar opened to a 500-guest list. Beverage bills are the least planned and most exceeded line in Indian weddings.
- 20 Renting decor structures for a single function instead of designing reuse across mehendi, haldi and sangeet.
- 21 Trousseau shopping spread across the year at full price instead of the festive-window sales in October.
- 22 Registration left until after the honeymoon, hitting the 30-day notice rule or portal slot shortages in peak weeks.
- 23 Destination weddings without travel logistics in the contract: guest shuttles, airport pickups and hotel transfers are where hidden lakhs go.
- 24 Paying the last retention on the wedding night itself. Hold 10-20% until deliveries complete; it is your only quality lever.
- 25 Borrowing from friends and family informally (6.25% of families do, per WedMeGood) without a written schedule. Weddings end; memory of who owes what does not.

## 17. Invitations, Gifts and the Shagun Ledger

The small lines nobody budgets are, together, not small. CAIT's sector study puts gift items at 4% of all wedding expenditure, dry fruits and sweets at 5%, and invitations run 2-3% of a typical family budget. On a Rs. 25 lakh wedding, that is Rs. 2.5-3 lakh spent across a hundred small decisions, each too minor to negotiate and too many to skip.

### Invitations: printed, boxed or sent

The invitation has split into two products: the printed card and the announcement. The card still goes to elders, family and anyone who will frame it; the announcement, a digital invite with the wedding website link, goes to everyone else. Online invitation platforms are growing 20-25% a year in wedding-related sales per CAIT, and a digital invitation with RSVP tracking costs a fraction of a printed batch. If you print, print in tiers: heavyweight cards for the two hundred who expect them, simple cards for the rest, digital for the travellers.

The box is the trap: cards inside dry-fruit boxes, chocolate boxes, miniature photo frames. A Rs. 400 box across 400 invitations is Rs. 1.6 lakh of packaging your guests will open once. The tasteful single card, or a small sweet box bought in bulk during the festive-season sales, delivers the same courtesy at a quarter of the cost.

### Return gifts and favours

- Set one per-family gift budget before shopping, and buy in bulk during October's festive discounting, not in the November rush.
- Prefer Indian-made and local artisanal gifts: over 70% of wedding purchases are now Indian-made per CAIT, and local crafts photograph and gift better than imported trinkets anyway.
- Skip per-guest favours at large functions; keep them for the intimate ones where they are noticed.
- Sweets and dry fruits in the wedding season run at a premium; book them early, or gift at the smaller functions instead of the largest one.

### The shagun ledger

Keep a two-column ledger for every wedding in the family: who gave, and how much. Record in front of two people, the evening of each function, while envelopes are being counted and deposited. Three reasons this discipline pays. Reciprocity: the same names will appear at the next family wedding, and memory is a poor ledger. Planning: shagun is real money against the loan or the shortfall, and Chapter 11's advice is to deploy it immediately. Evidence: in the rare bad case of theft or dispute, a contemporaneous record is what insurers and police work with.

The two-person rule: envelopes are counted by two people, recorded the same evening, deposited the next morning. Cash left in the house after a wedding function is the single most avoidable loss at Indian weddings.

## 18. Master Checklists and Budget Worksheet

### The 12-month plan (for 2027 weddings)

Month by month, working back from a February 2027 wedding

| When                            | Do this                                                                                                                                                           |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 12-10 months out (Feb-Apr 2026) | Set the family budget and ceiling. Fix the date from the muhurat calendar with your pandit. Decide city vs destination and guest-count range.                     |
| 10-8 months (May-Jun 2026)      | Shortlist and book the venue (line-item quote, segregated GST). Book the photographer. Start the gold or reset plan for inherited jewellery.                      |
| 8-6 months (Jul-Aug 2026)       | Book caterer, decorator, makeup artist, mehendi. Order trousseau at festive-season sales. Open the wedding bank account.                                          |
| 6-4 months (Sep-Oct 2026)       | Invitations and guest list finalised. Book travel and room blocks. If marrying under the Special Marriage Act, check notice timing. Get wedding insurance quotes. |
| 4-2 months (Nov-Dec 2026)       | Fittings, menu tastings, sangeet prep. Confirm all contracts and advances in the ledger. Negotiate anything unbooked in the Karmas lull.                          |
| 2-0 months (Jan-Feb 2027)       | The last-30-days protocol from Chapter 14. Registration appointment booked. Envelope system, insurance printed, final confirmations out.                          |

### The 6-week sprint (for the November-December 2026 window)

- Week 6: Accept reality and buy speed. Weekday dates (24 or 25 November; 2, 3, 4 December) or 11-12 December still have inventory; 21 November and 5 December likely do not.



- Week 5: Five venue quotes same-day, on the same guest count; sign the best on a line-item contract with a 25-30% advance and a written cancellation clause.
- Week 4: Book photographer, caterer and decorator; ask each for their 11-12 December cancellation resells, where last-minute deals live.
- Week 3: Clothes (rent the single-wear pieces), makeup, mehendi, DJ. Register on your state portal now if using the Hindu Marriage Act route.
- Week 2: Final counts, minimum guarantee, insurance on the advances, envelope system, and the joint site visit.
- Week 1: The last-30-days protocol compressed to days: written confirmations, payment schedule from the ledger, one empowered person per function.

## Your budget worksheet

Fill this in, update it weekly (all figures in Rs.)

| Category                   | Budget | Quoted | Advance paid | Balance | Actual |
|----------------------------|--------|--------|--------------|---------|--------|
| Venue                      |        |        |              |         |        |
| Catering                   |        |        |              |         |        |
| Decor and flowers          |        |        |              |         |        |
| Photography and video      |        |        |              |         |        |
| Jewellery                  |        |        |              |         |        |
| Clothes                    |        |        |              |         |        |
| Makeup and mehendi         |        |        |              |         |        |
| Music and entertainment    |        |        |              |         |        |
| Invitations and gifts      |        |        |              |         |        |
| Travel and logistics       |        |        |              |         |        |
| Registration and paperwork |        |        |              |         |        |
| Insurance                  |        |        |              |         |        |
| Contingency (10%)          |        |        |              |         |        |
| TOTAL                      |        |        |              |         |        |

Print the worksheet, or rebuild it in a spreadsheet with a variance column. However you keep it, the discipline is the same: every quotation, advance and payment gets recorded the day it happens, and the totals get checked against the ceiling you set in Chapter 3 every single week.

## 19. The Words on Every Vendor Quote: A Glossary

Thirty terms you will hear this season, in the order you are likely to meet them. A first-time buyer who knows the vocabulary gets better quotes; it is that simple.

## The vendor's dictionary

| Term                               | What it means                                                                                    |
|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Per plate</b>                   | Caterer's price per guest per function, usually before GST and service charge.                   |
| <b>Minimum guarantee (MG)</b>      | The plate count you pay for even if fewer guests eat.                                            |
| <b>Composite supply</b>            | Services naturally bundled in one contract at one rate; venue plus catering is the classic case. |
| <b>Mixed supply</b>                | Bundling that attracts the highest applicable tax rate on the whole amount.                      |
| <b>GSTIN</b>                       | A vendor's GST registration number; no GSTIN, no valid tax invoice.                              |
| <b>Input tax credit (ITC)</b>      | The credit vendors claim on their inputs; why 5% catering usually comes without it.              |
| <b>Service charge</b>              | A venue or caterer's percentage fee on food bills, distinct from GST.                            |
| <b>Muhurat</b>                     | The auspicious time window fixed by the panchang for the ceremony.                               |
| <b>Lagna</b>                       | The exact moment within the muhurat when the ceremony is solemnised.                             |
| <b>Chaturmas</b>                   | The four-month pause on auspicious ceremonies; in 2026 it ends 20 November.                      |
| <b>Kharmas (Dhanurmasa)</b>        | The solar month, 16 December to 14 January, when weddings pause again.                           |
| <b>Mandap</b>                      | The ceremonial canopy structure; a major decor line on every quote.                              |
| <b>Baraat</b>                      | The groom's procession; drives overtime, transport and logistics costs.                          |
| <b>Varmala / Jaimala</b>           | The garland exchange, and the most photographed three minutes of the day.                        |
| <b>Roka / Sagai</b>                | The engagement functions; budget them as functions, not as teas.                                 |
| <b>Shagun</b>                      | Cash gifts; plan their use against the loan or the shortfall before the wedding.                 |
| <b>Trousseau</b>                   | The couple's clothing and personal effects; a budget line of its own.                            |
| <b>Haldi, mehendi, sangeet</b>     | The pre-wedding functions; each is a venue, decor and catering decision.                         |
| <b>BIS hallmarking</b>             | The mandatory purity certification on gold jewellery.                                            |
| <b>Making charges</b>              | The craftsman's fee, quoted per gram or as a percentage; negotiable.                             |
| <b>Wastage</b>                     | Metal lost in crafting, charged separately by some jewellers; ask if it applies.                 |
| <b>Polki / Kundan</b>              | Uncut-diamond setting; kundan is the glass-based imitation of it.                                |
| <b>22K vs 24K</b>                  | 22-carat (91.6% gold) is jewellery grade; 24-carat is near-pure and mainly for coins and bars.   |
| <b>CIBIL score</b>                 | The credit score lenders price your loan on; above 750 unlocks the best bands.                   |
| <b>EMI</b>                         | Equated monthly instalment; fixed through the tenure on a fixed-rate loan.                       |
| <b>Foreclosure</b>                 | Closing a loan early; check charges and lock-in before you sign.                                 |
| <b>Sum insured</b>                 | The maximum an insurance policy pays; set it to what you cannot afford to lose.                  |
| <b>Deductible</b>                  | The first slice of a loss you bear yourself, stated in the policy.                               |
| <b>Surveyor</b>                    | The insurer's assessor who inspects and values a material damage claim.                          |
| <b>Notice of intended marriage</b> | The 30-day public filing required under the Special Marriage Act.                                |

## 20. Appendix A: One Wedding, Line by Line

A composite family, assembled from the category shares and market rates in this book: a Delhi family marrying on Saturday 5 December 2026, three functions (mehendi at home, sangeet, wedding with reception), 280 guests at the main function, a stated ceiling of Rs. 24 lakh including a 10% contingency. Every figure is illustrative, but every line behaves the way the market behaved in the 2025-26 season. Read the Actual column as the story, and the lessons underneath as the point.

### The Khurana wedding ledger, Delhi, December 2026 (Rs. lakh)

| Line                                     | Budgeted | Actual | What happened                                                                      |
|------------------------------------------|----------|--------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Banquet venue, sangeet (150 guests)      | 1.50     | 1.50   | Booked in August; weekday-flexible family accepted a Sunday brunch slot.           |
| Banquet venue, wedding and reception     | 2.80     | 3.00   | Peak Saturday, 5 December; paid the scarcity premium after comparing five halls.   |
| Catering, sangeet (150 x Rs. 1,100)      | 1.65     | 1.65   | As quoted; MG set at 130.                                                          |
| Catering, wedding (280 x Rs. 1,150)      | 3.22     | 3.45   | MG set at 260; 268 ate. The 280-count quote included a bar that ran over.          |
| Catering, mehendi at home (60 x Rs. 800) | 0.48     | 0.42   | Family cook plus one outside counter; simplest and cheapest function.              |
| Decor, three functions, one theme        | 2.40     | 2.10   | Continuity pricing and structure reuse delivered a discount (Chapter 6).           |
| Photography and video, two days          | 2.00     | 1.80   | Package reshaped to two-day candid plus same-evening reel (Chapter 9).             |
| Clothes, couple and family               | 1.80     | 1.72   | Two outfits rented; one designer lehenga bought.                                   |
| Jewellery                                | 1.50     | 0.95   | Family gold reset for the bridal set; making charges only (Chapter 7).             |
| Makeup and mehendi artists               | 0.60     | 0.60   | Booked early for the December window.                                              |
| DJ, sound and light                      | 0.80     | 0.85   | Overtime on the sangeet night, 1.5 hours at the contracted rate.                   |
| Invitations, printed and digital         | 0.35     | 0.28   | Two hundred printed, rest digital with RSVP site.                                  |
| Gifts, favours and sweets                | 0.70     | 0.66   | Bought in the October festive sales.                                               |
| Transport and logistics                  | 0.50     | 0.55   | Guest shuttles on the wedding night.                                               |
| Registration and paperwork               | 0.10     | 0.08   | Hindu Marriage Act route, Delhi; Tatkal not needed.                                |
| Contingency (held, not spent)            | 2.40     | 0.90   | Half went to the venue premium and catering overage; the rest returned to savings. |

Illustrative composite by the author, anchored to the category shares in Chapter 2 and the 2025-26 market data used throughout this book.

The totals: Rs. 21.08 lakh budgeted across lines, Rs. 21.61 lakh spent, within a Rs. 24 lakh ceiling once the unspent contingency returns to savings. Four moves made the difference between a wedding that fit and one that did not. The guest list was cut from 320 to 280 names in the first week, worth about Rs. 1.7 lakh in catering and gifts alone. The bridal set was reset from inherited gold, saving Rs. 55,000 at a moment when gold stood near Rs. 1.49 lakh per 10 grams. Decor was contracted as one theme across three functions instead of three separate designs. And the photography package was rebuilt around what

the couple would actually consume, which is where the 2025 market has moved anyway.

What the ledger would look like if the family had skipped those four moves: roughly Rs. 24.5 lakh spent against a Rs. 24 lakh ceiling, with no unspent contingency and a Rs. 2 lakh shortfall arriving exactly when the final vendor payments did. That is the version of this wedding that ends in a rushed personal loan at 16% because it was pre-approved. The difference was not wealth; it was a number set in advance and four decisions made against it.

## 21. Appendix B: The Vendor Question Bank

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Print the section you need before each meeting. No vendor should get your signature without surviving their list, and no quote is comparable until every vendor has answered the same questions for the same date and guest count.

### The venue (ask every one of these)

- What is included in the rental: hours, setup and teardown time, power backup, parking, changing rooms, bridal suite?
- Is the decorator in-house or empanelled, and what is the outside-decorator buyout fee?
- What is the minimum guarantee, and can unused plates convert to vendor meals or next-day breakfasts?
- What is the cancellation and date-change policy, and what happens to the advance if the date moves within the season?
- Which taxes apply to which lines, and is the quote inclusive or exclusive of GST?
- Is there a service charge on food, and is it a percentage or a flat staffing fee?
- What is the overtime rate if the baraat runs late, and until what hour is music permitted?
- Are there restrictions: caterer exclusivity, alcohol licensing, outside food, timing curfews?
- What rooms or room blocks come with the booking, and at what rate for guests?
- Who is the single point of contact on the wedding day, reachable by phone through the night?

### The caterer

- What is the per-plate price for each menu tier, all-in, with service charge, staffing and GST separated?
- What is your minimum guarantee, and how is the final count confirmed?
- How many live counters and servers are included per hundred guests?
- When is the tasting, and can we taste the exact menu at the tier we are buying?
- What is the charge for children, and for the crew and vendor meals?
- What is your policy on menu changes after booking?
- What backup do you run if equipment or staff fail on the day?
- Do you hold the required licences (FSSAI), and is your GSTIN on the invoice?

### The photographer

- Who exactly shoots our wedding, and what happens if that person is unavailable?
- How many edited photos, and in what turnaround?

- What do the deliverables include: teaser, reel, album, raw footage, cloud delivery?
- Who owns the raw files, and is the delivery date contractual?
- What is the overtime charge if the function runs past the booked hours?
- What is your backup plan for equipment failure on the day?
- Can we reshape the package around two functions instead of three days?
- What is the advance, the balance schedule, and the retention after delivery?

### The decorator

- What does continuity pricing across all functions look like versus per-event designs?
- Which structures, drapes and lights are reused across venues?
- What flowers are in season and locally sourced in our wedding month?
- What is the plan for wind, rain or heat at an outdoor venue?
- What is included in the mandap quote, and what is charged extra?
- Who dismantles, and by when; what is the venue's teardown window?
- What is the waste and cleanup responsibility?

### The makeup artist, the DJ and the planner

- Makeup: trial included or separate; products used; timing per look; travel included; who is the backup artist?
- Makeup: what is the charge per additional function or family member?
- DJ: equipment list, sound limits at the venue, MC or anchor included, and the overtime rate?
- DJ: empanelment restrictions at our venue, and backup equipment on site?
- Planner: what exactly do you manage versus coordinate, and who is our single point of contact?
- Planner: what is your fee structure, and what commissions do you receive from vendors you recommend?
- Planner: what is your cancellation policy if the date moves within the season?

The last question, for everyone: 'What is the one thing families usually forget to ask you?' Vendors answer it honestly, and the answers are often the most useful sixty seconds of the meeting.

## 22. Appendix C: The Two-Family Split

Every negotiation in this book is with vendors. The harder ones are internal: who pays for what. Indian weddings carry unspoken expectations about which side carries which costs, they vary by community, region and family, and nothing causes more friction in the final month than a cost assumed by one side and expected from the other. Put the split on paper in the same meeting where you set the ceiling.

One boundary first, stated plainly. Dowry, any payment or valuable demanded in connection with marriage, is prohibited under the Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961. Voluntary gifts are treated differently in law, but the line is thin and families should stay on the right side of it deliberately: every gift voluntary, recorded, and from the giver's own means. A cost split is between families who are celebrating, not parties who are transacting; keep it that way and the paperwork follows easily.

## The split families actually use

Patterns differ by community and region, so treat these as options to pick from, not rules to follow. What matters is that both sides have chosen and written down the same option.

- The roka or engagement: hosted and funded by one side as a full function, with its own budget line; the other side funds the exchange of gifts on the same day.
- The wedding day: in much of North India traditionally hosted by the bride's family, in many South and West Indian traditions by the groom's; whoever hosts, the venue, catering and main decor travel together as one budget.
- The reception: commonly hosted in the groom's city and funded by the groom's family; often the mirror-image function of the wedding day.
- Jewellery and clothes: each side typically funds its own, whatever the tradition, because it is the line where expectations most easily outrun means.
- The honeymoon: increasingly funded by the couple, or given jointly as a wedding gift by both families.
- The modern middle-class pattern: a joint wedding account funded by both sides in proportion to capacity, with the one-off personal lines (jewellery, clothes) kept with each family.

## How to hold the conversation

- Each side states its number privately to the couple first, then jointly at the meeting; an open auction, where each side escalates to save face, is the most expensive way to arrive at a budget.
- The couple's own contribution counts, and naming it changes the dynamic from two families funding an event to two families and two adults co-funding a life event.
- Agree an escalation rule in advance: if the total rises past the ceiling by more than 10%, who funds the excess, and what gets cut instead.
- Write the one-page memorandum: each function, its host, its funding, signed at the money meeting. It is the cheapest argument-prevention document in Indian family life.

## 23. Appendix D: Budgeting the Smaller Functions

The main function gets the negotiation; the smaller ones get the leakage. A mehendi that began as 'just family' becomes a hundred-person evening with a decor theme, two food counters and a DJ, each booked casually because each seemed small on its own. Across mehendi, haldi and sangeet, families routinely spend a quarter of the total without ever budgeting a rupee of it.

### The tiered-function rule

- Tier one, at home (mehendi, haldi): one caterer or home cooking, flowers and fabric for decor, no stage, no DJ. These functions photograph on people and colours, not production.
- Tier two, single rented venue (sangeet): one hall, one DJ or band, decor from the same decorator on continuity pricing, a capped menu. Set the cap before the choreographer is booked, not after.
- Tier three, full banquet (wedding with reception): the main budget, negotiated per Chapter 6, with the smallest viable guest count.

The sangeet is the dangerous one: choreographer, dance floor, stage, lights and an anchor can add up to a second wedding if uncapped. Decide what the sangeet is: a family evening with prepared dances, or a produced show. The first costs a fraction of the second, and at most Indian sangeets the family dances

are what people remember anyway.

## Menu strategy that lowers the per-plate

- Per-plate price is a function of menu tier and counter count, not quality: three strong live counters read better and cost less than a fifteen-dish buffet.
- A regional menu (South Indian, Rajasthani, Bengali, Kashmiri) reads premium and sources locally; pan-Indian multi-cuisine is the most expensive way to feed a mixed room.
- One excellent dessert beats a counter of five; nobody remembers the fifth dessert.
- Confirm the child rate and the vendor-meal rate; both are negotiable and both are commonly forgotten until the final bill.
- For home functions, one signature counter from a good caterer plus home cooking beats three average counters; ask the main caterer for a family-function rate while negotiating the wedding.

One last habit for all the smaller functions: they are booked by whoever is closest to them, usually without the main budget in view. Keep every small-function booking inside the same ledger and the same weekly review as the wedding; the total stays honest when the parts share one page.

## Sources

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- Loan rates: HDFC Bank marriage-loan product page (updated October 2025); BankBazaar and MyMudra lender comparisons, 2026.
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- Marriage registration: Delhi Revenue Department and Maharashtra Inspector General of Registration official checklists and fee schedules.
- Wedding calendar: Drik Panchang-based muhurat compilations and panchang services, verified September 2026; confirm final dates with your family pandit.
- Wedding market context: Jefferies India wedding-market analysis via Weddingkart; IBEF and IMARC market reports.

This playbook is general financial and planning information for Indian families, current as of 29 September 2026. It is not investment, tax or legal advice; interest rates, GST rates, fees and schemes change. Verify current figures with the lender, insurer, tax practitioner or registrar before acting, and confirm all dates with your family pandit.